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CAPTAIN OF THE CASTES

BIHAR CM NITISH KUMAR BOWLS ANOTHER GOOGLY WITH THE CASTE SURVEY RESULTS, PUTTING THE BJP ON THE BACK FOOT AND CATAPULTING HIMSELF TO CENTRE STAGE AGAIN

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

Nitish Kumar likes to wear his watch with the dial on the inside of the wrist. If you ask him why, he might dismiss it as just an old habit, but it's one way to keep an eye on the time without others noticing. On October 2, Gandhi Jayanti day, the Janata Dal (United) boss and Bihar chief minister again showed his keen sense of timing as his government released the data it had collected from the caste count conducted earlier this year.

It could have done so immediately after the Supreme Court, on September 6, adjourned the hearing of petitions challenging it, but Nitish waited for the BJP to play its card with the Women's Reservation Bill before dealing the caste count blow. The saffron party's somewhat confused response to the gambit in Bihar—Union minister Giriraj Singh called it an attempt to mislead the masses, former deputy CM Sushil Modi claimed equal credit for the exercise while state BJP president Samrat Choudhary and former Union minister Ravi Shankar Prasad alleged that the numerical strength of the castes opposed to Nitish and Rashtriya Janata Dal patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav has been manipulated—underlines how difficult it has become for the BJP to articulate a consistent political response.

With the caste survey confirming overwhelming numbers in favour of the backwards (63.1 per cent in Bihar), Nitish's demand for a quota within quota under women's reservation could gain momentum and neutralise the BJP's 'masterstroke'. This quantifiable confirmation of data could also see the OBC and EBC (Extremely Backward Classes, a subdivision in the OBC categorisation) preferring regional parties over national parties like the BJP as they seek more (proportional) representation in Parliament.

"The survey throws up many pertinent questions. For instance, why do the privileged caste Rajputs, with just 3.4 per cent of the population, have the maximum number (seven of the total 40) of Lok Sabha MPs from Bihar? Why do the Yadavs, who make up four times the Rajputs in numbers, have just 5 MPs? These questions can force political parties to rethink their electoral strategies," says a senior JD(U) leader. If the demand for proportionate representation starts growing, the parties will be forced to rejig their responses accordingly. This could make and unmake careers.

There are two distinct components to the caste survey. The largest chunk of the OBCs is the Yadavs, the support base identified with Tejashwi Yadav's RJD. The caste group was always seen as the single-largest, but the authentication (14.3 per cent) is expected to consolidate them even more, which could close the door on the BJP's dreams of making a decent dent in the RJD's vote base.

The second is the EBC or the *ati pichhda* population, made up of 112 castes from among the most marginalised OBCs in Bihar. The news that they make up 36 per cent of the population can make these caste groups more homogeneous than before when it comes to poll choices.

In his heyday, when RJD supremo Lalu Prasad Yadav used to quip, "Ballot box *se djinn niklega*" to counter the doomsday predictions, the djinn he was referring to was the support from the EBCs. The EBCs, who for long failed to unite into a single political entity, used to back Lalu in elections in the '90s. That changed after Nitish's innings began in November 2005. He carved the EBCs out of the Mandal bloc and breathed new life into the idea of empowerment by first offering them a stake in local governance (with 20 per cent reservation), and then expanding it with financial assistance to meritorious EBC youth